

Facilitating (Neuro)-Inclusion in the Workplace

Reed Senter, Ph.D.



connect

Disclosures

- I am an Assistant Professor of Speech-Language Pathology at DeSales University.
- I am neurodivergent. My inclusive ideology is influenced by my identity and informed by my experiences.

Objectives

Attendees will be able to:

- Understand how to support neurodivergent individuals in the workplace.
- Adapt their communication style for neurodivergent individuals.

The background is a solid red color. Overlaid on this are several large, semi-transparent red shapes. A prominent feature is a large 'X' shape formed by two diagonal bands crossing in the center. Additionally, there are two large, rounded rectangular shapes, one on the left and one on the right, which are also semi-transparent red. The text 'What *is* neurodiversity?' is centered horizontally and vertically in a white serif font.

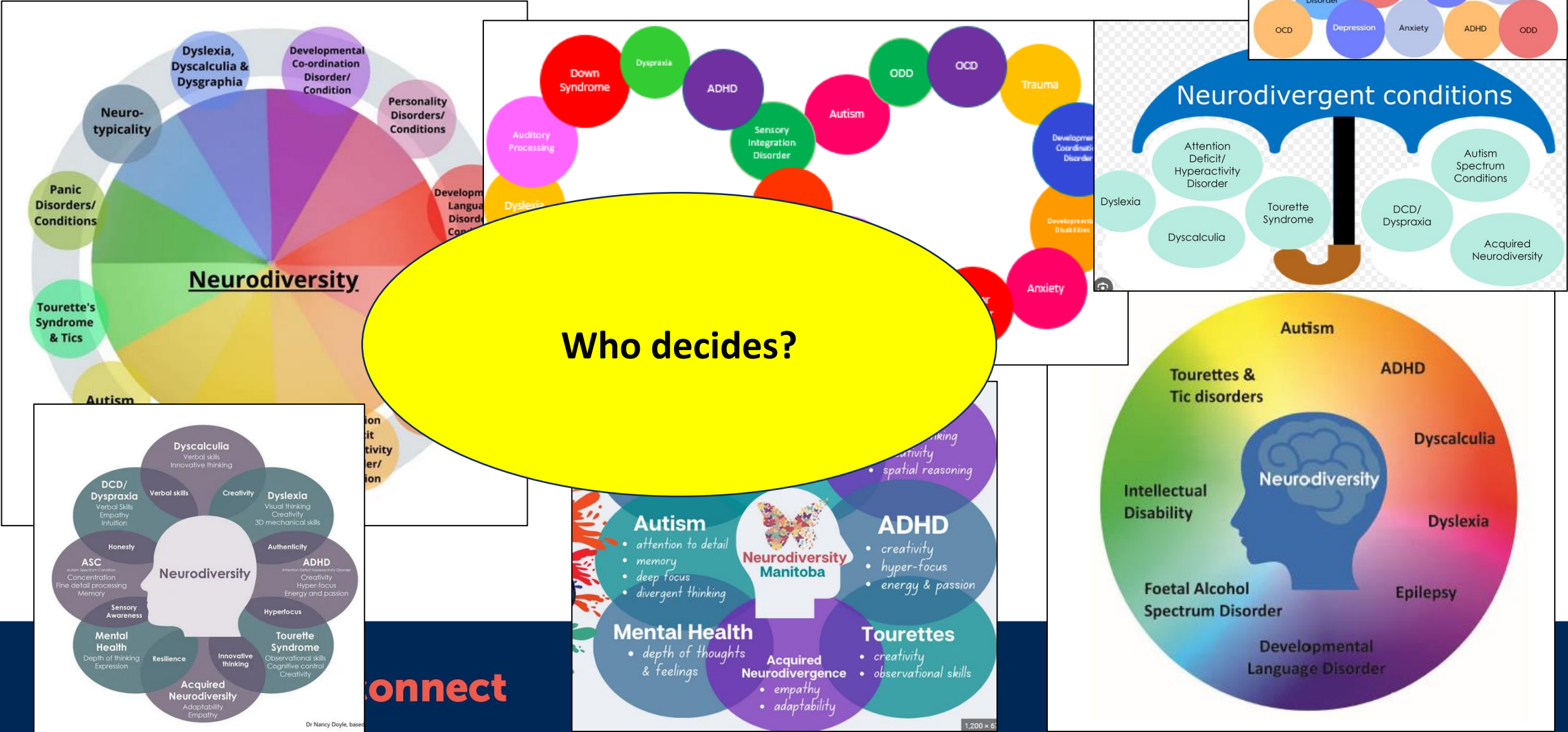
What *is* neurodiversity?

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- = “Intrinsic diversity in human brain function and cognition”
 - Biological fact, not opinion!
- May or may not refer to disabilities
 - Clinical significance: Characteristics of neurotype vs. the functional impact
 - “Disability” as a social construct—how does one perceive their neurotype?



Neurodiversity = Umbrella term



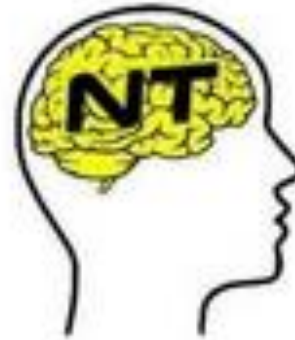
Terminology

NEURODIVERGENT v NEURODIVERSE



**Each of these people is
NEURODIVERGENT**

(There are lots of ways to be neurodivergent)



**This person is
NEUROTYPICAL**

**Only a group
can be
NEURODIVERSE**

**An individual
can not.**

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- ...But also, neurodiversity is a:
 - Paradigm
 - Socio-political movement
 - Identity & community
 - *(And it started as satire!)*

A stylized illustration of a person. The head is a large circle with a rainbow gradient, transitioning from green at the top to blue on the left, purple at the bottom, and red on the right. It has two small black dots for eyes. The body is a simple pink shape below the head.

SOCIAL MODEL

OF DISABILITY

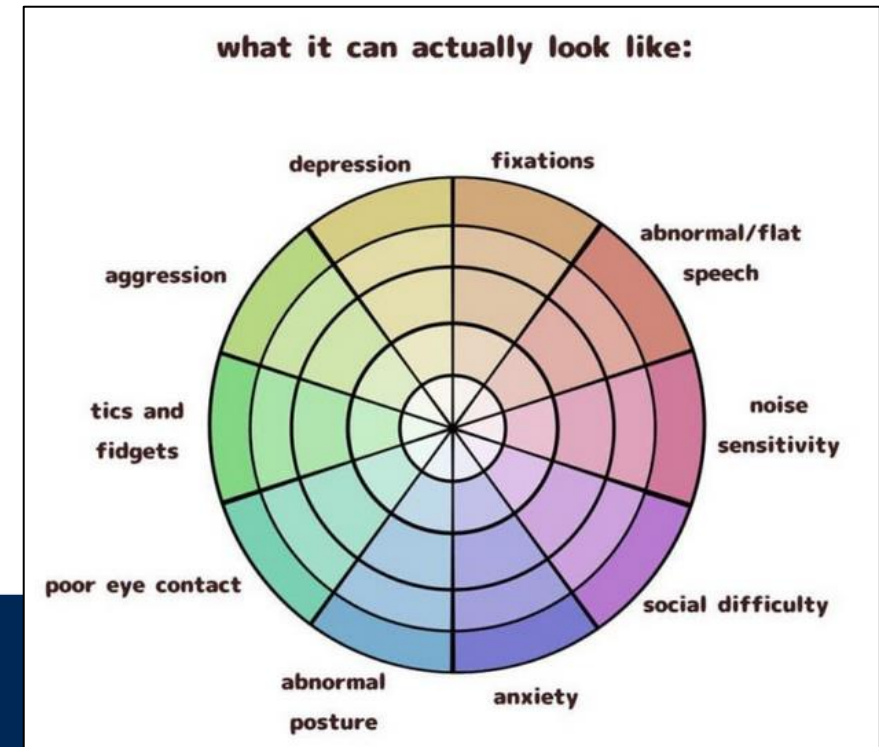
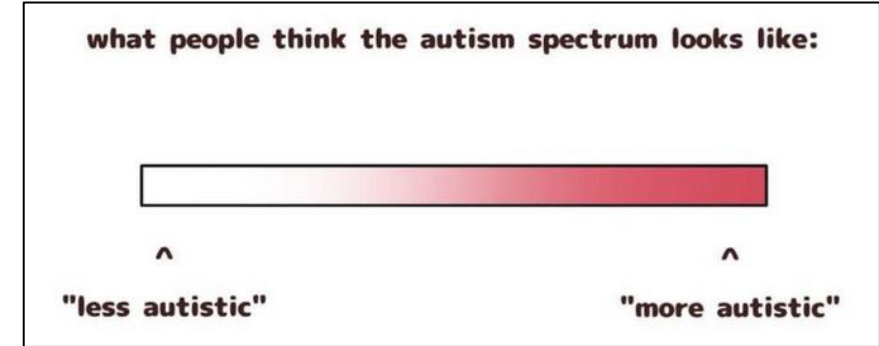
AUTISM



Differing Minds

Variations of neurodivergence

- Considerable within-group variation
 - E.g., “If you know one person with autism, you know *one person* with autism.”
- Considerable intra-person variation
 - Because neurodivergent characteristics aren’t static!
- Considerable between-group overlap
 - Hence myths like “isn’t everyone a little bit autistic?”
 - Or, “That’s not unique to autism, *everyone* does that sometimes.”



Why should we
encourage
neurodiversity?

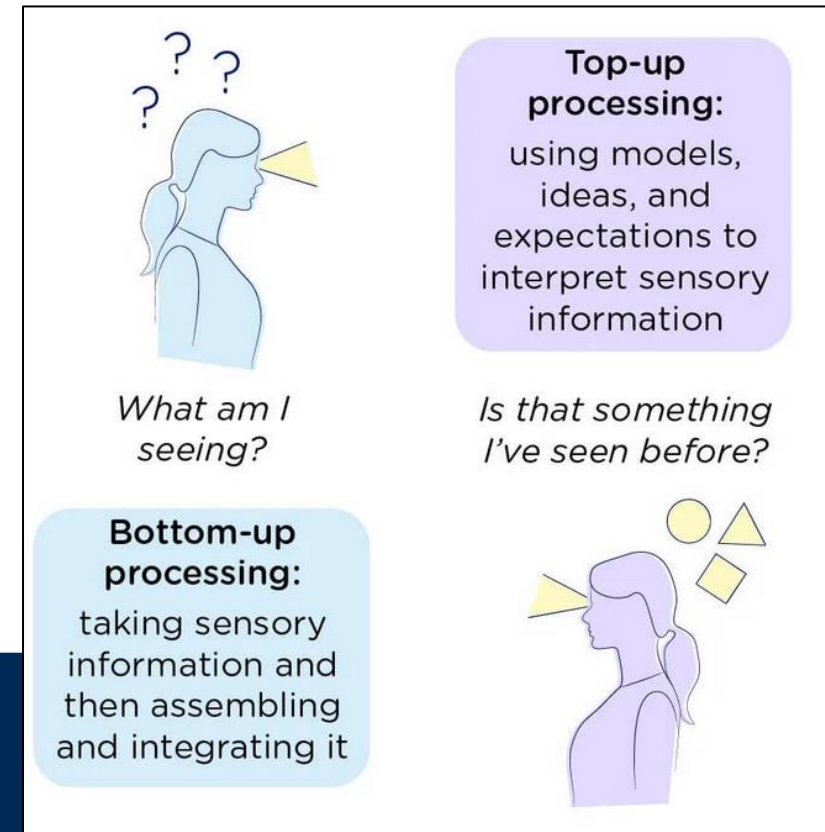
Advantages of neurodiversity

1. Distinct cognitive processing yields fresh insight

- “Top-down” processing vs. “Bottom-up” processing
 - Pattern recognition
 - Attention to detail



**Do you see
the forest or
the trees?**



Advantages of neurodiversity

2. Different sets of strengths and weaknesses

- Executive function differences
 - Hyperfocus?
- “Spiky” profiles of strengths and weaknesses
 - E.g., hyperlexia

Reframing Neurodivergent Traits

Learning to view natural traits positively is a crucial step toward radical acceptance and learning to work with your brain, rather than against it.

Demanding → Decisive	Impulsive → Spontaneous
Stubborn → Persistent	Clingy → Loving
Bossy → Leader	Restless → Active
Obsessive → Orderly	Defiant → Courageous
Fixated → Focused	Demanding → Assertive
Shy → Introspective	Impractical → Innovative
Rigid → Precise	Picky → Discerning
Fearful → Cautious	Goofy → Joyful
Hyper → Energetic	Nosy → Curious
Impatient → Eager	Sneaky → Inventive
Moody → Passionate	Talkative → Outgoing
Emotional → Empathetic	Anti-social → Introvert
Dramatic → Expressive	Rash → Intuitive
Loud → Exuberant	Unrealistic → Creative

@dmmorganbeideman

Advantages of neurodiversity

3. Understanding of other neurodivergent perspectives

- “Double-empathy problem”

Simon, 2012

Neurotypical people are good at interpreting other people's thoughts and perspectives.

Autistic people are bad at interpreting other people's thoughts, feelings and perspectives.

There's power when we **connect**

DOUBLE EMPATHY PROBLEM

Communication between same neurotype

From neurotypical to neurotypical

From autistic to autistic



Efficient



What challenges might neurodivergent people encounter?

And how can we support them?

Difficulty with learning



1. Bottom-up processing

- Can't see the “big picture”
- Difficulty seeing how information relates
- Poor generalization of skills/knowledge

2. Black-and-white thinking

- Difficulty resolving contradictory (or seemingly-contradictory) info

Support with:

Multimodal, active instruction

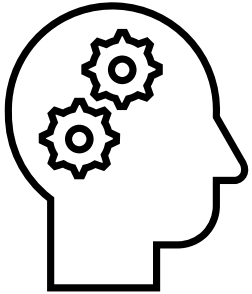
- “I do, we do, you do” teaching
- Pairing verbal explanation with written instructions, visual aids/diagrams, video tutorials

Support by:

Explaining your rationale

- Understanding why we do things can help people understand:
When & where to use these skills
- Why others might not do these things

Difficulty with executive function



3. Planning, organization, and execution of complex tasks
- Also includes meeting deadlines, avoiding procrastination, multi-tasking

Support with:

Clear procedure & systems

*Consider checklists or step-by-step procedural instructions;
Breaking large tasks down into smaller steps*

Support with:

Consistent routines

Includes routines for specific tasks, as well as general, daily procedures

Support by:

Offloading cognitive demands

Use [shared] calendars, to-do lists, bullet journals, etc., to reduce demands on memory

Environmental & sensory challenges

4. Sensitivity to lighting, noise, interruption

Support with:

Modified environment

- “Warm,” non-fluorescent lighting
 - Quieter work space
- Positioned away from distractions (incl. apps, “push” notifications...)



Support with:

Individualized supports

- Brimmed hats to manage lighting
- Noise-cancelling headphones, earplugs, etc.



Communication & interaction

5. Communication differences and social challenges

- Social nuance (formal, informal)
- Tone
- Directness/bluntness
- Communication/listening “behaviors”
 - E.g., eye contact



Are *you* being understood?

- *Communicate clearly, directly, simply*
 - *Check for understanding*
- *Avoid reliance on figurative language, “hinting,” or body language*

Consider:

Providing feedback on communication style

- *“When you say/do ____, people hear ____”*

Selecting the right communication modality

- *Written vs. spoken communication*
- *Multimodal communication*

Considerations

1. Are we setting people up for success?
 - Direct instruction & training
 - Ongoing mentorship, feedback
 - Universal accommodations
2. Where do we draw the line?
 - It's not about lowering standards!
 - Traditional perspective: Force people to conform to “norm.”
 - ND-affirming perspective: Embrace differences, reject “norms.”
 - Your perspective: *Somewhere in between?*

Support worksheet

 Individual's strengths and needs: <i>Consider broad skills (organization, communication) or specific task-based skills</i>	 It helps when people: <i>Consider how you can modify your own communication, teach others about condition, improve accessibility...</i>
	 Prompt for personal factors: • Self-awareness • Autonomy & independence • Connectedness with peers • Motivation • Accountability
 Things I can do: When I have trouble, I can: • Prompt for strategies the individual uses, or would be willing to consider How I want to learn/practice: • Discuss how the person would like to be trained, taught, etc.	



My **strengths** and **needs**:



It helps when **people**:

Other things that help:

It's easy to: 

I prefer to:

I have questions about:

MY GOAL:

Things I can do:

When I have trouble, I can:

How I want to learn/practice:



Download this worksheet!



Questions / Discussion

Reed Senter

Reed.Senter@desales.edu